and Pakistan's continued support for international terrorism, contributed to these evolving perceptions.

Perhaps the last gasp of India–Pakistan hyphenation was the 26/11 terrorist attacks in Mumbai in November 2008. For the previous few years, as cross-border infiltration declined following the 2003 ceasefire, Pakistan-based terrorist groups had begun a new strategy of targeting urban centres in India, such as Mumbai, Delhi, Bengaluru, and other cities across India. High-level talks between India and Pakistan continued despite these regular incidents of terrorism. The two countries continued to be engaged in a formal Composite Dialogue on a range of issues, while a backchannel between special representatives of the two leaders made progress towards a deal on Jammu and Kashmir. The process began unravelling as Pakistani President Musharraf faced popular protests in 2006 and 2007. Elections following the assassination of Benazir Bhutto in late 2007 resulted in a weak civilian government in Pakistan. But the November 2008 attacks in Mumbai—televised in real time around the world and targeting foreigners—brought an end to this phase of difficult India–Pakistan talks. The Composite Dialogue was suspended. While in previous years, major attacks had resulted in fears of external intervention by New Delhi, India in fact received greater international sympathy and New Delhi benefited from intelligence and investigative cooperation with Western agencies after 2008. India also initiated a major rehaul of its intelligence and counter-terrorism apparatus. US relations with Pakistan deteriorated after this time, culminating in the May 2011 raid on Abbottabad in which Osama bin Laden was killed. This incident also contributed to the popular international perception of Pakistan as a centre of international terrorism. [44]

Two additional regional developments of considerable significance occurred during this period. One concerned Nepal, which had become embroiled in a civil war between the government and Maoist forces. In February 2005, King Gyanendra—who had succeeded his brother in 2001 following the massacre of most of his family—seized absolute power and declared a state of emergency. Indian diplomats and intelligence agencies brokered a deal between the seven major political parties and the Maoists,